

Order One New Thing.

A spec campaign concept by Sresha Rajesh. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Starbucks.

CLIENT	Starbucks (2026 holiday menu launch)
DISCIPLINE	Product marketing: positioning, segmentation, messaging, launch tiering, sales enablement
DELIVERABLES	Interactive pairing tool • Product marketing launch brief • This case study
STATUS	Spec campaign. Independent concept work, not a real client engagement.

The Launch Problem

Starbucks' 2026 holiday menu launches on Nov. 5 with four new drinks (Tiramisu Velvet Latte, Tiramisu Velvet Cold Brew, Apple Pomegranate Refresher, Snowy Apple), three new food items (Bearista Cake Pop, Braised Short Rib Grilled Cheese, Turkey & Stuffing Sandwich), and returning favorites including the Peppermint Mocha, Caramel Brulée Latte, Sugar Cookie Latte, and Gingerbread Chai.

Awareness is not the challenge. The holiday menu is one of the most anticipated seasonal launches in food and beverage. The challenge is trial. The Peppermint Mocha, introduced in 2002, is described by Starbucks as the most popular holiday beverage in its history, which means many loyal customers already have a holiday order and may never try anything new.

Positioning

For Starbucks Rewards members who already have a holiday ritual, the 2026 holiday menu is the season's reason to add one new thing to the order they already love. Unlike a menu that asks customers to switch, it keeps the favorite and gives them a low-risk way to try something new.

The Product Marketing Work

- Segmentation: three behavior-based segments (The Ritualist, The Afternoon Seeker, The Lunch Stopper), each with a distinct job to be done. These are hypotheses to validate against Rewards purchase data.
- Messaging house: one umbrella message ("Keep your favorite. Order one new thing.") and three pillars, each backed only by proof points from Starbucks' own announcement.
- Launch tiering: Tier 1 hero (Tiramisu Velvet), Tier 2 reach (Apple Pomegranate Refresher, Snowy Apple), Tier 3 anchor (returning favorites, food, merch). Tiering decides where paid media and attention go.
- Sales enablement: two short barista lines for the register, because the counter is the last and most persuasive channel.
- Risks and mitigations: new items overshadowed by returning favorites, pairing feeling pushy, and Red Cup Day having no announced date.

Deliverables Prototyped

- Order One New Thing pairing tool: choose a returning favorite and get one new item to add, with a plain-language reason and a food add-on. Pairing logic is an illustrative concept, not a Starbucks recommendation.
- Launch brief: a one-page product marketing document covering the problem, positioning, segments, messaging house, launch tiers, barista lines, timeline, and risks.

How This Would Be Measured

Because this is spec work, there are no real results to report. If it ran, this is how it would be measured:

- Primary KPI: new-item trial rate among customers whose recent holiday orders were a returning favorite.
- Secondary KPIs: food attach rate on holiday beverage orders, share of holiday orders placed in the Starbucks app, and repeat order rate for new items after first trial.
- Channels: Starbucks app (home screen, push, order prompts), short-form social video, in-store menu boards and register scripts.
- Budget split (illustrative): 40% owned and CRM (app and email), 35% paid social and video, 25% in-store enablement and materials.
- Test plan: A/B test pairing-led creative ("keep your favorite, add one new thing") against new-flavor-led creative to see which drives higher trial among returning-favorite buyers.

A Note on Accuracy

Menu details, the Nov. 5 launch date, and merchandise dates are from Starbucks' own holiday menu announcement. The Peppermint Mocha's 2002 introduction and its description as the most popular holiday beverage in company history are from Starbucks' newsroom story on the drink. Red Cup Day is announced with no date. Segments, tiers, messaging, pairings, barista lines, and all measurement plans are original creative work and are not real Starbucks strategy or performance data. Details may change, so re-check about.starbucks.com before sharing publicly.